

WELL TRAVELLED Mumbai driver being checked by RTO squad over Marathi language requirement, Aug. 20

ANI

MAHARASHTRA

METER DOWN OVER MARATHI

The Shinde Sena moves to take ownership of the language card—in a bid to distance itself from the BJP

a conscious cultivation of that legacy, the Shinde Sena has pitched to make functional knowledge of Marathi mandatory for taxi and auto drivers in Maharashtra. What that did, more than anything else, is bring to the fore a fundamental divergence within the Mahayuti.

The one to set it rolling was the flamboyant transport minister Pratap Sarnaik, who shares the striking fact of once having been an autorickshaw driver in Thane—like his party boss, Shinde. In July, Sarnaik declared August 15 as the deadline for taxi and auto drivers to demonstrate working knowledge of Marathi, and threatened to revoke the licences of those who lacked it. On August 12, the new Maharashtra Motor Vehicles (Third Amendment) Rules, 2026, were notified. App-based vehicles, too, were brought within its ambit, and language tests were set to begin.

This created consternation among the city's 700,000 or so commercial passenger vehicle drivers. Roughly 60-70 per cent of them are estimated to be from 'Hindi belt' states like Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. Inter alia, that makes them more inclined towards the BJP, whose stakes in north India debar it from taking too provincial a stance on this count. Sure enough, the uproar soon led to chief minister Devendra Fadnavis extending the deadline by a year. A BJP leader admitted the impending election in UP was a factor.



Takeaways

- **Transport minister Pratap Sarnaik of the Shinde Sena issues fiat making Marathi a must for autos/cab drivers**
- **BJP eases deadline by a year—can't antagonise Hindi speakers, UP polls a factor**
- **Shinde also ups ante on mayor's post, Mumbai Bank**

TWO BIRDS WITH ONE STONE

He also had an explanation for the Shinde Sena's sudden championing of the Marathi cause. "It realises it has little footprint among the core Marathi base of the undivided Sena in and around Mumbai, and is raking up such issues to slice into that vote," he says. Uddhav Thackeray's Sena UBT holds on to key segments of the legacy vote in Mumbai; Raj's Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) is still a presence too. As much as that sibling feud within the Sena universe, though, it's also a theme that helps sharpen Shinde's political boundaries vis-a-vis the BJP.

That he has ambitions on that front became clearer when Shinde publicly asserted his party's claim as the next in line for the mayor's position in the Brihanmumbai Municipal Corporation (BMC). Setting the cat among the pigeons, the deputy CM declared in late August that a Sena nominee would become the city's first citizen after the two-and-a-half-year term of the new incumbent, Ritu Tawde, ends in 2028.

The BMC election earlier this year